

VISIT · CCTSI, UNIVERSITY OF COLORADO ANSCHUTZ MEDICAL CAMPUS · 7 OCTOBER 2026

Valuing the Hub Function

Crediting support for other institutions' research



Toshiki Saito, MD, PhD

Professor / Director, Clinical Research Promotion Center
The University of Tokyo Hospital

CCTSI, Aurora

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Where we stand

It shapes what we hope to learn.

Hospital

The University of Tokyo Hospital is one of Japan's 16 Core Clinical Research Hospitals.
The criteria I describe today apply to the center I run.

National

Representative Secretary, NUH-CRPI
The council of all national university hospitals: 42 universities, 44 hospitals.

Data

Vice Chair, Japan CDISC Coordinating Committee · AMED principal investigator
Clinical data standards. This layer comes next.

Not one hospital's site visit: we came for a national system that is deciding how to measure its research hubs.

Japan's networks, and why a CTSA hub

Japan has national hospital networks, but no hub program.

42 + 44

National university hospitals

A council: 42 universities, 44 hospitals.

It shares practice and speaks with one voice.

✗ Not a funded hub for its members' studies

NHO 140

National Hospital Organization

140 hospitals, with its own ARO and data center.

A network with a center.

... But inside one organization

CCTSI

One hub, a whole state

Funded to serve several universities, hospital systems and community partners.

✓ What Japan does not have

That is why we chose the CCTSI, and why we wanted to see the CTSC before talking.

Japan's Core Clinical Research Hospitals

Created by law in 2015. The Minister approves hospitals that meet published criteria; 16 hold the designation today.

CTSA award (US)

Nature	A grant
Entry	Compete and win
Review	Periodic; the award can end
Steering	A national program office

Core hospital (Japan)

Nature	A legal status
Entry	Meet the published criteria
Review	Kept until it fails the criteria
Steering	No program office, no peer competition

The criteria are the whole instrument, so what they count matters.

What the criteria count

Three things, measured over the previous three years.

8

Trials

Investigator-initiated trials for drug approval, or 4 of them plus 40 other trials

In principle, led by the hospital's own investigator

45

Papers

Peer-reviewed English papers

In principle, the first author is from the hospital

15

Supports

Studies supported at other institutions, per year. Mandatory, but a floor

15 and 50 score the same

A study led from outside counts only if the hospital's ARO takes on **the whole package**: protocol, data management and monitoring.

The hub function is what the instrument measures least.

What happens as a result

What we see from inside the Core Hospitals: our observation, not yet a quantified study.

- ✕ **Small, easy-to-start trials.** Eight in three years is a hard number, and a small trial counts the same as a large one.
- ✕ **More papers.** Forty-five is a hard number too.
- ✕ **Support is penalized.** Every statistician, data manager and dollar moved to another institution's study is not spent on the hospital's own count.

The Ministry knows this. Its review this year keeps support as a floor, because the effort behind support varies too much to be scored.

That is exactly the problem your funders have had to solve.

Three shifts we propose

Re-weight counting, do not abolish it. Each shift has a working counterpart in how NIH funds research infrastructure.

1 Input → outcome

Count trials that finish and report. Judge approvals and guideline changes case by case, over a longer period.

2 In-house → support

Credit research the hub enabled at other institutions as the hub's own achievement.

3 Single site → network

Cross-cutting infrastructure at the core; disease-specific networks carry the rest.

NIH review, in the funding announcements we read (CTSA hubs, TIN, coordinating centers of Duke, the CCTSI and Vanderbilt): no in-house trial counts, no first-author papers, no points or weights. Reviewers judge coordination, data and statistics, consortium contribution and dissemination.

Two layers of NIH money, FY2025

Base layer: CTSA hubs

\$7–11M (¥1.1–1.8B) per hub, small differences

\$0.57B (¥91B)

Competitive layer

coordinating, data and statistical centers

\$1.0B (¥160B) · where institutions differ · what Japan lacks

What we came to ask

Thirteen written questions in seven themes; you have grouped the answers for 10:10. DCRI sharpened three.

Value

Which numbers NCATS actually reacts to, and how you credit research led at partner institutions

Not whether in-house counts are reported: we now know they are not.

Themes A–C

People

The size of the support workforce, and how you keep trained staff

DCRI: culture, and turnover under 6%. What about here?

Theme D

System

How a hub relates to the other research organizations around it, and data standards

Megumi Kitayama (people) and Akira Soma (data standards) wrote these questions and will follow up.

Themes E–G

So let me go straight to what we most want to learn.

What we most want to learn

One question is about the review; two are specific to you.

1

The review itself

Your UM1 was renewed in 2023 under the current structure. What actually decided it? Since then, which numbers in your annual reports has NCATS ever acted on?

2

Our question three

If hub designation required a minimum number of in-house trials or first-authored papers, how would the CCTSI and its statewide partners change?

3

The hub and the ARO

At Duke, the CTSA hub and DCRI barely meet. How do the CCTSI and CPC Clinical Research relate: shared faculty, shared services, or separate worlds?



CCTSI, UNIVERSITY OF COLORADO ANSCHUTZ · 7 OCTOBER 2026

Thank you



Now I would much rather hear from you.

Our thirteen written questions

Written questions sent on 24 August · for 10:10–10:20 · in the order we sent them

A	Demonstrating value and attributing outcomes	Q1–3
B	Governance and decision-making	Q4
C	Funding and sustainability	Q5
D	Research support workforce	Q6–9
E	Evaluating the CTSA program	Q10
F	Data standards and infrastructure	Q11–12
G	An integrated ecosystem, and what comes next	Q13

A · Demonstrating value and attributing outcomes

Written questions sent on 24 August · for 10:10–10:20

- 1** Which indicators do you use to demonstrate the value of the CCTSI in your reporting to NCATS? Are the number of principal investigators based at the hub institution, or the number of first-authored papers from the hub institution, among them — and if so, how much weight do they carry relative to your other indicators?
- 2** Of the studies the CCTSI supports, what share have a principal investigator based at a partner or external institution? How do you account for the results of the research you support as the hub's own achievement?
- 3** If hub designation were to place greater emphasis on measures such as a minimum number of trials conducted in-house, or a minimum number of first-authored papers from the hub institution, how do you think the CCTSI's operation and priorities would change?

B · Governance · C · Funding and sustainability

Written questions sent on 24 August · for 10:10–10:20

- 4** Which body decides what the CCTSI supports and in what priority, and on what criteria?
How are competing requests from across your partner institutions reconciled?
- 5** What is the balance between NCATS funding, institutional funds, and recharge income?
How do you think about the financial sustainability of support units such as the CTRC,
particularly across award cycles?

D · Research support workforce (1 of 2)

Written questions sent on 24 August · for 10:10–10:20

6

What is the size and composition of your research support workforce — coordinators, biostatisticians, regulatory staff, data managers, and others?

7

In Japan, obtaining a PhD is one possible career path for experienced research support professionals who want to advance. We noticed that the CCTSI also offers Research Service Professionals the opportunity to pursue master's or doctoral degrees through the Clinical Science Graduate Program. Besides obtaining an advanced degree, what other career pathways are available to Research Service Professionals at the CCTSI?

Follow-up from our side: Megumi Kitayama (Q7–9)

D · Research support workforce (2 of 2)

Written questions sent on 24 August · for 10:10–10:20

- 8 Approximately what proportion of eligible research professionals actually take up these degree opportunities and the associated tuition support? And once they have completed the program, what strategies do you have in place to retain these highly trained professionals within the CCTSI or its partner institutions?
- 9 If a data manager or research coordinator identifies a methodological research question through their routine work, how could they develop that idea into a research project at the CCTSI? Are there internal funding schemes, mentorship arrangements, or protected time that support this?

Follow-up from our side: Megumi Kitayama (Q7–9)

E · CTSA evaluation · F · Data standards and infrastructure

Written questions sent on 24 August · for 10:10–10:20

- 10** Is there any independent evaluation showing that the CTSA program has improved clinical research outcomes in your region or nationally? Which findings from such evaluations have you found most useful in practice?
- 11** How does the CCTSI approach the standardization and interoperability of clinical research data across different studies, systems, and institutions? In particular, how are standards such as CDISC being used, or considered, within your research ecosystem?
- 12** As clinical and translational research becomes increasingly data-driven, what do you see as the key technical and data-infrastructure challenges — and the key opportunities — in supporting research that spans multiple institutions?

Follow-up from our side: Akira Soma (Q11–12)

G · An integrated ecosystem, and what comes next

Written questions sent on 24 August · for 10:10–10:20

- 13** The CCTSI brings together multiple universities, healthcare organizations, and community partners. From your perspective as Director, what are the organizational challenges and opportunities in building an integrated research ecosystem across these partners, and where do you see the greatest opportunities for collaboration in the coming years?